MauiGearSwap.com

Draft Business Plan v0.3

1. Executive Summary

MauiGearSwap.com is a peer-to-peer marketplace for travelers to buy, sell, give away, and find free used vacation gear in tourist destinations. The simple idea is "OfferUp for vacation gear", focused on items travelers often need temporarily but do not want to fly with, rent expensively, or leave behind.

The first launch market will be Maui, with an even narrower first test in Kihei. Maui is a strong starting point because it has steady visitor demand, beach-heavy travel behavior, and an existing rental market for chairs, umbrellas, snorkel gear, boogie boards, coolers, wagons, and similar items. Maui had 223,227 visitors in February 2026 and $571.5 million in visitor spending, according to Hawaii DBEDT. [1]

MauiGearSwap.com will use a classifieds-style model: listings will be free to post and will expire automatically. Future revenue is expected to come from optional paid listing promotions. The MVP will offer no paid services; the pilot will evaluate the model's potential profitability.

The MVP will be a simple website, not native apps at first. It will allow travelers to list gear, browse available items nearby, filter by pickup location and availability dates, and coordinate simple transactions.

The goal is to validate demand cheaply before investing in a full marketplace app.

2. Business Concept

MauiGearSwap.com helps travelers get free or affordable used vacation gear from people leaving the same destination, use it during their trip, and sell it or pass it on for free before going home.

Simple positioning:

> *Get it free or buy it. Beach it. Pass it on.*

The product is not just a generic marketplace. It is built around vacation timing, local pickup, trip dates, and high-demand vacation gear categories.

3. Problem

Travelers visiting beach and vacation destinations often need bulky gear for only a few days, such as:

- Beach chairs
- Umbrellas
- Coolers
- Snorkel gear
- Boogie boards

- Beach wagons
- Kids' beach toys
- Strollers
- Camping, hiking, fishing, and outdoor gear

Buying these items new is wasteful and inconvenient. Renting can be expensive or limited. Bringing gear on a flight is annoying and often unrealistic.

Many visitors end up buying cheap gear, using it for a week, and then abandoning it, donating it, or trying to sell it last minute.

At the same time, departing travelers have gear they no longer need, and arriving travelers are looking for the same items.

4. Solution

MauiGearSwap.com connects departing travelers, local residents, hosts, and arriving travelers in one simple marketplace.

The platform should make it easy to answer three questions:

1. What gear is available near me?
2. Can I pick it up before or right after I arrive?
3. Can I sell it before I leave?
4. is the gear available near?
5. is the gear available at a certain time?

The biggest product difference from a generic marketplace is that listings are organized around:

- Vacation destination
- Pickup area
- Availability date
- Seller departure date
- Gear category
- Resale potential

5. Target Customers

Primary Customers

Traveling families visiting Maui who need beach and kid-friendly gear for a short stay. Departing visitors who bought gear and want to recover some money before leaving.

Secondary Customer Group

Local residents, Airbnb hosts, vacation rental managers, and small gear owners who want to earn money by reselling or repeatedly listing reusable gear.

6. Initial Market

The first test market should be Maui, starting with Kihei (west side).

Why Kihei (or west side)

Kihei is a strong starting point because it has:

- Tourist-heavy areas
- Beach-focused travel behavior
- Many condos and vacation rentals
- Easy local pickup patterns
- Strong fit for chairs, umbrellas, coolers, snorkel gear, beach toys, and wagons
- Lots of hotels and vacation homes, all in one area which would be easy to make advertizing.

There are already commercial rental options in Maui offering snorkel sets, beach chairs, umbrellas, boogie boards, surfboards, wagons, coolers, and other beach gear. That confirms demand exists, but MauiGearSwap.com would compete with a cheaper, peer-to-peer, resale-first model, with no obligations. [2]

7. Lean Canvas

Problem

Travelers need temporary vacation gear, but buying new, renting, or flying with gear is often inconvenient or expensive.

Departing travelers often have useful gear they no longer need.

Customer Segments

Primary:

- Families visiting Maui
- Travelers staying in condos, Airbnbs, and vacation rentals
- Visitors who need beach gear for 3 to 14 days

Secondary:

- Departing tourists
- Local residents with unused gear
- Airbnb hosts and vacation rental managers
- Small rental operators who want extra visibility

Unique Value Proposition

MauiGearSwap.com helps travelers get free or affordable vacation gear from people leaving the same destination, use it during their trip, and sell it or pass it on for free before going home.

Existing Alternatives

- Renting from local beach gear shops

- Buying new from Costco, Walmart, Target, or local stores
- Using Facebook Marketplace, Craigslist, or OfferUp
- Borrowing from Airbnb hosts
- Leaving gear behind

Key Metrics

- Active listings
- New listings per week
- Search-to-contact rate
- Contact-to-exchange rate (sales and free pickups)
- Average time to completed exchange
- Listings sold or given away before the lister’s departure
- Repeat sellers
- Top searched categories
- Buyer complaints or no-shows

Revenue Streams

The MVP will have no paid services. Posting listings and arranging exchanges will be free. Buyers will pay sellers directly at pickup; the platform will not process gear payments or charge transaction fees.

Potential revenue after the pilot:

- Optional paid listing promotions, with $2 per promotion as an initial pricing hypothesis
- Optional subscriptions for promotion bundles, including possible host or property manager plans, subject to validation

Future platform payments will cover promotional services only. The pilot will assess demand, willingness to pay, and operating costs before introducing monetization.

Cost Structure

- Domain and hosting
- Basic marketplace tools
- Payment processing fees for promotional services after the MVP
- Admin and moderation time
- Local marketing
- Flyers or QR cards
- Legal templates and liability terms

Unfair Advantage

The main advantage is focus.

Generic marketplaces are not built around travel timing, departure dates, resort areas, and vacation gear categories. MauiGearSwap.com can win by being simpler and more relevant for one specific use case.

8. MVP Strategy

MVP Goal

Validate one question:

> *Will travelers in Kihei use a simple local marketplace to buy, sell, or give away vacation gear?*

The MVP should not try to be a full app or a full marketplace. It should test liquidity in one small area.

Launch Market

Start with:

- Maui
- Kihei first
- Vacation equipment across beach, camping, hiking, fishing, and family travel categories, subject to listing rules
- Web-first product
- No native mobile app yet

9. MVP Product Scope

The MVP should stay very small.

MVP Features

- Browse without creating an account
- Create an account on demand when a user submits a listing or subscribes to updates, with email verification
- Let returning users access their listings through a secure sign-in link or one-time code sent to their email; no public seller profile required
- Post a listing
- Upload photos
- Item title, category, price or Free label, and condition
- Pickup location
- Availability dates
- Seller departure date
- Search and browse listings
- Basic messaging or contact flow
- Mark an item as sold, given away, or unavailable

- Admin account with extended permissions for listing review, moderation, monitoring, and alerts

Important Filters

- Available today
- Available this week
- Near my location
- Custom pickup dates and time windows
- Seller leaving soon
- Item category
- Price range and a Free-only filter
- Sorting by newest listing, price, pickup area or distance where available, and seller departure date

MVP Categories

Allow vacation equipment beyond beach gear. Initial categories include:

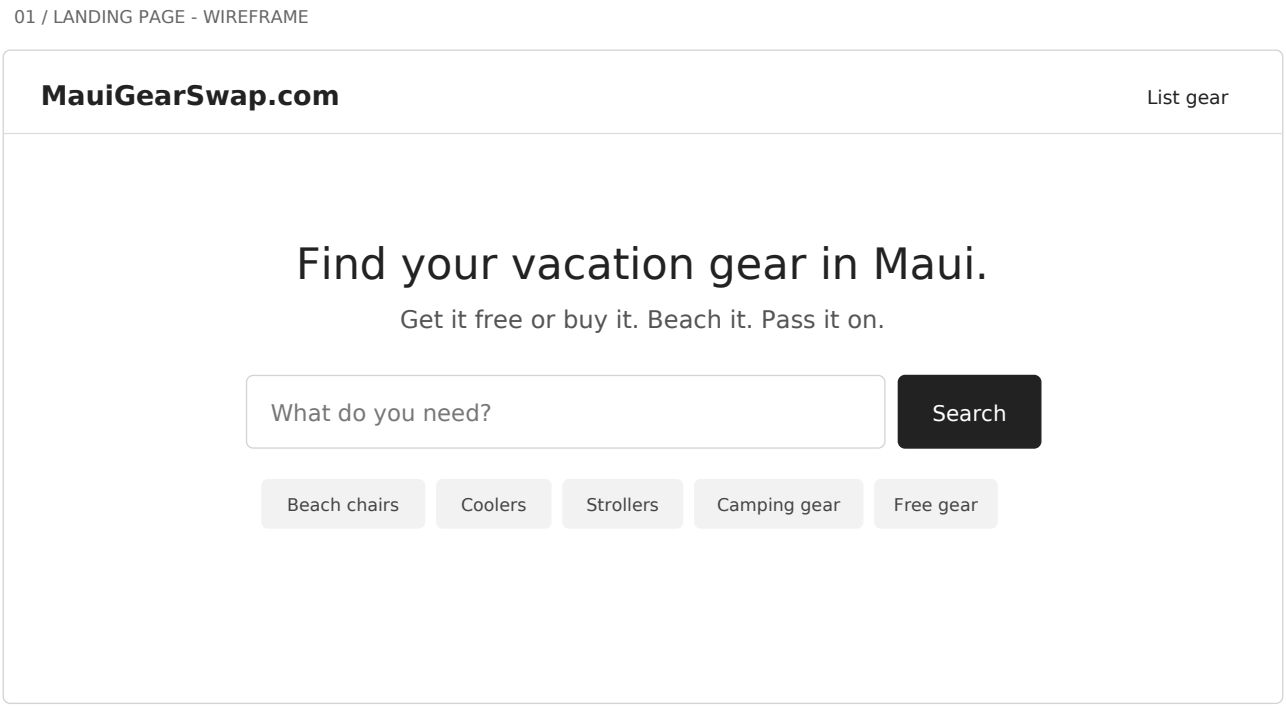
- Beach chairs
- Umbrellas
- Coolers
- Boogie boards
- Kids' beach toys
- Beach wagons
- Camping gear
- Hiking gear
- Fishing gear
- Strollers and other permitted family travel equipment
- Surfboards and paddle boards

Each category remains subject to condition and prohibited-item checks. Snorkel gear requires a hygiene and condition review before its category is enabled. Beach gear can lead the initial supply effort without limiting the marketplace to beach items.

10. MVP Screens

1. Landing Page: Search First

Purpose: help visitors start a search immediately, with minimal content.



Content:

- Header: MauiGearSwap.com and List gear
- Headline: "Find your vacation gear in Maui."
- Tagline: "Get it free or buy it. Beach it. Pass it on."
- One prominent search input with the placeholder "What do you need?" and a Search button
- Suggested searches: Beach chairs, Coolers, Strollers, Camping gear, and Free gear

Keep the initial page free of listing grids, promotional banners, and long explanations. Browsing and searching do not require an account. The tagline remains beach-oriented while search supports all permitted vacation equipment.

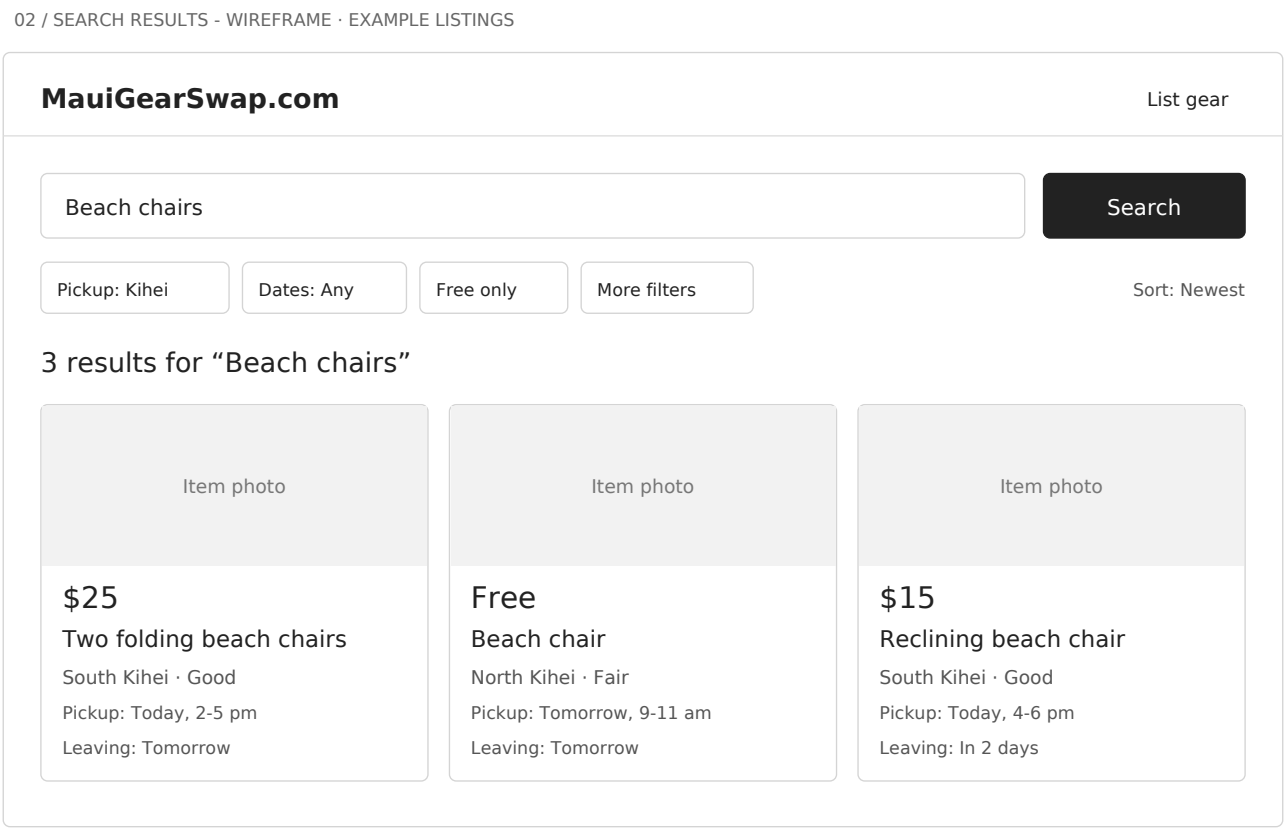
Search behavior:

- Pressing Enter or selecting Search submits the term and opens the separate search results page.
- Selecting a suggestion runs that search immediately. Free gear opens the results with the Free-only filter applied.
- Keep typed text in the input until submission; do not replace the landing page on every keystroke.
- Trim whitespace and keep empty searches on the landing page with a prompt to enter a term or choose a suggestion.

- Start with curated suggestions; do not label them as popular until actual search data supports that claim.

2. Search Results Page

Purpose: show matching available gear after a search is submitted.



The listings and result counts in the wireframe are examples, not live inventory.

Content and behavior:

- Keep the header and move the search input to the top of the results page, retaining the submitted term.
- Show the result count and search term, for example: 3 results for "Beach chairs".
- Match listing titles, categories, and descriptions. Exclude expired, sold, given-away, and unpublished listings.
- Show compact controls for pickup area, dates, Free only, and sorting. Place category and price-range controls under More filters.
- Date options include today, this week, and a custom pickup date or time window.
- Default to newest matching listings. Offer price, seller departure date, and distance sorting where location data supports it.
- Each result shows an item photo, title, price or Free label, pickup area, condition, pickup window, and departure timing.
- Selecting a listing opens its details page. Returning to results preserves the search and filters.

- Keep the query and filters in the page address so results can be bookmarked and shared, for example /search?q=beach+chairs&area=kihei.

States:

- Loading: show a brief "Searching…" indicator while results load.
- No matches: show "No matching gear yet. Try another search or broaden your filters."
- Search failure: retain the term and filters and offer a retry.
- Mobile: stack result cards in one column and group secondary filters behind a Filters button.

3. Listing Details

Purpose: help buyers decide quickly.

Content:

- Photos
- Item description
- Price or Free label
- Condition
- Pickup location
- Available pickup window
- Seller departure date
- Contact seller button
- Report listing button

4. Create Listing

Purpose: make it easy for sellers to post gear.

Required fields:

- Photos
- Title
- Category
- Price or Free label
- Condition
- Pickup area
- Available dates
- Departure date
- Contact preference
- Email address, verified before the first listing is published

Submitting a first listing creates the user’s account on demand. Returning users sign in through an emailed link or one-time code to manage listings. Subscription to updates requires separate opt-in and does not require a paid plan.

Optional fields:

- Brand

- Bundle option
- Notes about damage or wear

5. Message Seller

Purpose: coordinate pickup.

MVP options:

- Simple internal message form
- Masked email relay
- "Send inquiry" form that emails the seller

The first version can avoid real-time chat. Messaging can be simple and manual at the beginning.

6. Admin Dashboard

Purpose: keep marketplace quality high.

Admin needs:

- Review pending listings, photos, and automated risk flags before publication
- Approve, reject, or request corrections with a recorded reason
- Remove spam and prohibited listings
- Mark stale listings and review automatic expiry
- Handle user reports
- Monitor marketplace activity, listing checks, and service health
- Receive alerts for suspicious activity, overdue reviews, and service failures
- Keep a record of moderation actions

11. First User Acquisition Strategy

Main Strategy

The first goal is not brand awareness. The first goal is marketplace liquidity.

MauiGearSwap.com needs enough real listings in one small area so that arriving travelers immediately see useful inventory. The first launch should focus on Kihei, with initial supply outreach emphasizing beach chairs, umbrellas, coolers, wagons, boogie boards, and kids' beach toys. Other permitted vacation equipment can also be listed from launch.

The marketplace should not launch empty. A simple website with real inventory is more valuable than a polished product with no listings.

What To Do First

The recommended first move is:

> *Seed 20 to 50 real listings, build one Kihei landing page, then run a small Google Search ad test.*

The first steps should be:

1. Create a simple landing page for Kihei.
2. Add 20 to 50 real or clearly marked example listings.
3. Build a simple "list your gear" form.
4. Manually help the first sellers create listings.
5. Reach out to Airbnb hosts and vacation rental managers.
6. Test small Google Search ads.
7. Track which keywords and categories create buyer interest.

Do not start with YouTube ads. YouTube is better for awareness later, after the marketplace has inventory and proof that people are interested. Google describes Search campaigns as a way to show ads to people actively searching for products and services, while Video campaigns can support goals like sales, traffic, and awareness but require video assets and are better suited once the concept needs broader explanation. [3]

Example Listings Strategy

Seed the marketplace with realistic listings such as:

- 2 beach chairs, $30
- Beach umbrella, $15
- Small cooler, $20
- Kids' beach toy bundle, $10
- Boogie board, $20
- Folding beach wagon, $60
- Family beach bundle: 2 chairs, umbrella, cooler, $65

Every listing should include:

- Real photos
- Pickup area
- Available date
- Seller departure date
- Condition
- Simple pickup instructions

If sample listings are used before enough real supply is available, they must be clearly labeled as examples. The better approach is to create real starter inventory by partnering with local hosts, contacting existing sellers, or buying a small number of used items.

Supply Acquisition

The first supply push should target people who already have gear.

Best supply sources:

- Airbnb hosts
- Vacation rental managers
- Local residents

- Departing tourists
- Existing Facebook Marketplace sellers
- Craigslist sellers
- Small rental operators with older inventory
- Condo communities
- Cleaning crews who see abandoned guest gear

The first pitch should be simple:

> *Have leftover beach gear from guests? We can help you list it so incoming travelers can buy it instead of letting it go unused.*

The easier early pitch is not "join our marketplace." It is:

> *I can help you sell beach gear you already have.*

Demand Acquisition

Demand should focus on travelers who are already looking for a solution.

Best early demand channels:

- Google Search ads
- SEO landing pages
- Airbnb host referrals
- QR codes in vacation rentals
- Local travel groups
- Facebook groups, where allowed
- Reddit travel discussions, where allowed

Search intent is likely stronger than social ads because users searching for "beach chair rental Kihei" or "buy beach gear Maui" already have the problem.

Google Ads Plan

Google Search ads should be the first paid test.

Starting budget:

- $10 to $25 per day
- Run for 2 to 3 weeks
- Pause keywords that do not create inquiries
- Keep keywords that lead to listing views, seller messages, or signups

Initial keyword groups:

Buy used gear:

- used beach chairs Maui
- used beach gear Maui
- used beach chairs Kihei
- buy beach gear Maui

Rental alternative:

- beach chair rental Kihei
- beach gear rental Maui
- rent beach umbrella Maui
- Maui beach gear rental

Sell gear:

- sell beach gear Maui
- sell beach chairs Maui
- what to do with beach gear before leaving Maui

Example ad copy:

Headline:

Used Beach Gear in Kihei

Description:

Buy beach chairs, umbrellas, coolers, wagons, and toys from other travelers. Save money and resell before you leave.

Landing page:

MauiGearSwap.com/kihei

YouTube Ads Plan

YouTube ads should come later.

YouTube can help explain the idea visually, but it is not the best first validation channel. Early validation needs people who are ready to buy or sell now, not people casually watching travel videos.

Use YouTube only after:

- There are at least 100 active listings
- Google Search ads show buyer interest
- Hosts or sellers are adding supply
- The landing page converts visitors into inquiries

Future YouTube ad idea:

Flying to Maui? Do not buy beach gear twice. Buy it from another traveler, use it for your trip, and sell it before you fly home.

Airbnb Host Partnership Plan

Hosts could become one of the strongest acquisition channels because they interact with travelers before arrival.

Host pitch:

> *Your guests often need beach gear. Instead of buying new or asking you for supplies, they can use MauiGearSwap.com to buy affordable used gear nearby and resell it before checkout.*

Offer to hosts:

- Free listing access through verified email
- QR code for guests
- Help clearing leftover guest gear
- Help listing gear for their guests
- Optional referral fee later

This channel could work better than ads because hosts can introduce the service at the exact moment guests are planning their trip.

QR Code Strategy

Create simple cards or flyers for vacation rentals and local partners.

Example copy:

> *Need beach gear for your Maui trip?*
> *Buy used chairs, umbrellas, coolers, wagons, and toys from travelers nearby. Use them during your stay and sell them before you leave.*
> *Scan to browse Kihei gear.*

Potential QR locations:

- Airbnb welcome books
- Vacation rental check-in instructions
- Condo bulletin boards, where allowed
- Local cafes, where allowed
- Partner host properties
- Gear pickup locations

First 30-Day Launch Plan

Week 1:

- Build landing page
- Create listing form
- Add 20 real or example listings
- Write host outreach message
- Contact 20 Airbnb hosts or property managers

Week 2:

- Add 30 more listings
- Start Google Search ads at $10 to $25 per day
- Post in allowed local and travel groups

- Ask hosts to share QR code with guests

Week 3:

- Review ad results
- Identify most clicked categories
- Remove or adjust weak listings
- Personally help buyers and sellers complete transactions

Week 4:

- Decide whether demand is real
- Prioritize outreach for the highest-performing categories
- Add better pickup and date filters
- Start asking sellers to relist items before departure

Channel Priority

Recommended channel order:

1. Seeded real listings
2. Airbnb host partnerships
3. Google Search ads
4. SEO landing pages
5. Facebook groups and local communities
6. QR codes in rentals
7. Meta ads
8. YouTube ads

YouTube should not be the first channel. It is better for explaining the concept after the marketplace already has supply and some proof of demand.

Early Success Metrics

Track:

- Landing page visits
- Browse clicks
- Listing inquiries
- Listings created
- Active listings
- Reported completed exchanges, separating sales and free pickups
- Cost per inquiry
- Cost per listing
- Most popular item category
- Seller departure timing
- Buyer pickup timing

The most important early metric is not traffic. It is whether visitors contact sellers or list gear.

12. Revenue Model

Start simple.

MVP: Free Pilot

- All listings are free to post, including items offered for free.
- There are no paid promotions, paid subscriptions, or transaction fees during the MVP.
- Buyers pay sellers directly when they pick up gear; free items change hands without payment.
- The platform does not process gear payments.

The pilot will evaluate completed exchanges, user demand, willingness to pay for future promotions, and the cost of operating the service.

After the Pilot: Optional Promotions

Introduce paid listing promotions only after the pilot supports the case for them. A $2 promotion is an initial pricing hypothesis. Optional subscriptions could bundle promotions for frequent listers, hosts, or property managers; pricing and demand remain to be tested. Future platform payment processing will cover promotional services only.

Illustrative Revenue Target

At $2 per promotion, 500 paid promotions per month would generate $1,000 in monthly revenue before expenses. This is a future scenario, not an MVP revenue target or profit forecast.

Potential profit must account for hosting, moderation, support, marketing, and any future payment processing costs. The pilot will measure these costs while validating whether people successfully buy, sell, and give away gear.

13. Trust and Safety

Trust is one of the biggest risks in peer-to-peer travel marketplaces.

MVP trust features:

- Require current photos of the actual item and review them before publication
- Verify the lister’s email and use secure email sign-in for returning users; no public seller profile required
- Clear pickup location
- Clear item condition
- Report listing button
- Admin approval before publication for every listing during the pilot
- Basic marketplace rules
- Screen listings for prohibited, unsafe, or regulated items before publication
- Listings expire after departure date

Proposed Listing and Photo Review

1. Save each submitted listing as pending until its email verification and publication checks are complete.
2. Validate photo files and check for missing, unreadable, irrelevant, or repeated images. Use automated text and image screening to flag potential spam, scams, prohibited items, and mismatches between the description and photos.
3. During the pilot, have an admin review every listing and its photos before publication. Ask for another current photo, including a site-issued verification code beside the item, when ownership or authenticity is uncertain.
4. Check the item against the marketplace's prohibited-item rules and review its stated condition, visible damage, and relevant safety concerns. Hold uncertain listings for clarification or reject them with a reason.
5. Apply posting and inquiry limits to reduce abuse. Recheck material edits before republishing and provide a report button on every live listing.

These checks reduce risk but cannot prove ownership, authenticity, or physical safety. Photos and email verification must not be presented as a guarantee. Snorkel gear requires additional hygiene and condition criteria before its category is enabled.

14. Operations

At first, keep operations lightweight.

Manual review, manual support, and simple admin tools are acceptable early. The goal is to learn before automating too much.

Completed exchanges will be measured through users marking items as sold or given away and optional follow-up feedback, since gear payments happen offline.

Marketplace Monitoring

The admin account will provide a dashboard for marketplace activity and a queue for issues requiring attention. Track:

- Number of active listings
- Number of stale listings
- Messages per listing
- Share of listings reported sold or given away
- Time to completed exchange
- Buyer complaints
- Seller no-shows
- Most searched categories
- Most popular pickup areas
- Completed free exchanges as well as sales
- Pending reviews and time to publication
- Scam and spam flags, rejected listings, and repeat abuse

- Customer feedback and unresolved support requests

Alerts and Response

- Alert the admin when a user reports suspected fraud or an unsafe item.
- Flag bursts of duplicate listings, repeated failed checks, and unusual posting activity.
- Alert on listing review backlogs and failures in email delivery, uploads, or automatic expiry.
- Let the admin record an issue’s status, action taken, and resolution. Tune alert thresholds during the pilot to keep them useful.

15. Budget

Initial budget target: $2,000 to $5,000.

Suggested allocation:

- Domain, hosting, tools: $100 to $300
- MVP development: mostly self-built
- Design/assets: $200 to $500
- Initial paid marketing tests: $500 to $1,500
- Local flyers/QR cards: $100 to $300
- Legal/template terms: $500 to $1,500
- Buffer: $500 to $1,000

The biggest advantage is keeping the first version cheap by building a website first and avoiding native Android/iOS apps until demand is proven.

16. Success Metrics

First 30 Days

- 50 to 100 active listings
- 25 reported completed exchanges, including sales and free pickups
- 10 sellers who list more than one item
- 3 Airbnb host or property manager conversations
- Clear top 3 categories
- At least 30% of listings reported sold or given away; track other unavailable listings separately
- Customer feedback on finding gear, posting listings, pickup coordination, and trust; record recurring problems and suggested improvements

First 90 Days

- 500 listings created
- 150 reported completed exchanges, including sales and free pickups
- A tested hypothesis for promotion pricing and potential revenue, with measured operating costs; no MVP revenue target

- 3+ host or rental manager partnerships
- Clear evidence that Kihei can support repeat activity

17. Risks

Marketplace Cold Start

Risk: not enough listings or buyers at the same time.

Mitigation: seed listings manually, work with hosts, and focus on one small geography.

Trust and No-Shows

Risk: travelers have limited time, and bad transactions can damage trust quickly.

Mitigation: require real photos, clear pickup windows, verified email access, listing checks, and admin moderation.

Timing Mismatch

Risk: buyers and sellers may not be available at the same time.

Mitigation: emphasize seller departure date, available pickup window, and "available today" filters.

Competition From Rental Shops

Risk: Maui already has many rental options.

Mitigation: position as cheaper, resale-based, flexible, and more sustainable.

Seasonality

Risk: demand may change by travel season.

Mitigation: track visitor seasonality and expand to other destinations later.

Legal and Liability

Risk: some gear may create safety or liability concerns.

Mitigation: use clear terms, restrict categories, require condition disclosure, and avoid risky items in MVP.

18. Expansion Plan

Phase 1

Kihei first, with free listings for permitted vacation equipment across beach and other travel categories.

Phase 2

Expand across Maui and improve search based on pilot feedback. Consider reviews and optional paid promotions after validation; any platform payments will cover promotional services only. Gear payments remain offline at pickup.

Phase 3

Expand to other Hawaiian islands.

Draft and reference notes

This PDF reproduces the current working draft, which ends at Section 18, Phase 3. The remainder of the original conversation draft has not been recovered.

The original reference links were not retained in the retrieved draft. The numbered references identify the source subjects only; these claims have not been re-verified for this export.

[1] Hawaii DBEDT: Maui visitor counts and spending for February 2026.

[2] Maui commercial vacation gear rental offerings.

[3] Google Search and Video campaign guidance.